University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

8,518: The Managed Body at Work: A Cinematic Exploration

ECTS credits: 6

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (50%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Written work, Digital, Individual work individual grade (50%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,518,1.00 The Managed Body at Work: A Cinematic Exploration -- English -- Blagoev Blagoy Valentinov

Course information

Prerequisites

None.

Learning objectives

After successfully completing this course, students will be able to:

- critically reflect upon the role of the human body at work and how it has changed throughout the history of capitalism, which helps future
  practitioners in a grounded, reflected and playful way to interpret, question and engage in processes of creating, participating in and changing organizational life,
- analyze and interpret movie fragments as theoretical insights and practical exercises into organizational life and its relationship to management and the body,
- identify and analyze contemporary issues and practices related to the management of bodies at work as well as discuss their intended and unintended consequences,
- connect knowledge about work and management with insights from media and film studies.

Content

This seminar examines the role of the body in the world of work through its representation in cinema and television. From Chaplin's *Modern Times* and the feminist office satire *9 to 5* to contemporary classics such as *The Square*, *Toni Erdmann*, and *Bad Banks*, students will analyze the change role and the management of the body at the workplace, with a special focus on work-related transformations in digital capitalism. Combining perspectives from management and organization theory with cultural and film studies, the course invites students to critically reflect on the intersections of work, power, embodiment, and digital capitalism.

By focusing on cinematic representations of the body in workplace contexts, the course will allow students to critically reflect on how bodies, labor, and management techniques are depicted, negotiated, and contested through popular media. Through this lens, questions of power, control, discipline, resistance, affect, and embodiment become accessible to students in a way that bridges theory and (cultural) practice.

The course builds on a pedagogical strategy that emphasizes the role of visual media in contemporary society and the rich possibilities movies offer to see, sense and feel everyday social and organizational reality. Instead of the usual "paper case

study", we use movie-fragments and video clips to illustrate and interpret organizational episodes, and to generate change possibilities. With movies, we can zoom from the outside inwards and observe organizational life with a societal lens.

Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

The course will be delivered in a block format over the course of three days.

Day 1: Introduction and conceptual foundations

- Theoretical approaches to the body at work
- Analytical tools for studying movies
- Management, the body and the evolution of capitalism

Day 2: Historical roots of managing the body at work

- Industrial capitalism and scientific management
- White collar work and the "organizational man"
- Gendered bodies at work

Day 3: The managed body at work in contemporary capitalism

- Knowledge work, expertise, and competent bodies
- Algorithmic management and the body under digital capitalism
- Self-management, self-enhancement and the body entrepreneur

Throughout the entire course individual session will revolve around the discussion and analysis of selected movie fragments as well as student presentations.

Literature

These are introductory readings. A full list of literature will be provided at the beginning of the course.

Costas, J., Blagoev, B., & Kärreman, D. 2016. The arena of the professional body: Sport, autonomy and ambition in professional service firms. *Scandinavian Journal of Management*, 32(1): 10–19.

Michel, A. 2023. Embodying the Market: The Emergence of the Body Entrepreneur. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 68(1): 44–96.

Bell, E. 2008. *Reading Management and Organization in Film.* New York: Palgrave Macmillan. Introduction and Chapter 1, Reading film: Studying management.

Additional information

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Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/2)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral

Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	50%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
In-class presentation

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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2. Examination sub part (2/2)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	50%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
Reflection paper

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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Content

The course requirements consist of an individual reflection paper (50%) and a group presentation (50%).

Literature

Equivalent to the course literature.

Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).